Doing Applied Research

Mixtape Track

1. Useful phrases when writing up your results, statistical significance, and magnitude
2. Choosing a journal and submitting your manuscript
3. Responding to and writing referee reports
4. How to give an effective seminar

~~THE IMPACT OF CELLPHONE BANS IN SCHOOLS ON STUDENT OUTCOMES: EVIDENCE FROM FLORIDA~~

~~David N. Figlio~~
~~Umut Özek~~

~~Working Paper 34388~~
~~http://www.nber.org/papers/w34388~~

NATIONAL BUREAU OF ECONOMIC RESEARCH

"…while $\hat{\beta}_t$ are mostly statistically indistinguishable from zero at 5 percent level in the four panels of Figure 4A, positive effects of the ban on student disciplinary incidents in the first year are apparent. Similarly, we find positive effects of the ban on student test scores starting with the second test period of 2024-25 school year."

Useful Phrases When Describing Regression Results

- I find evidence of a negative relationship between years of schooling and earnings.
- The results suggest that schooling is negatively related to earnings.
- Consistent with the hypothesis that educational attainment affects earnings, I find that...
- A one-year increase in schooling is associated with a 6.8 percent increase in earnings.
- The estimate of β is .068, suggesting that an additional year of schooling leads to a 6.8 percent increase in earnings.
- The estimated effect of an additional year of schooling on earnings is positive 6.8 percent.

When Describing Regression Results…

- Don’t focus on statistical significance
- Do your best to characterize magnitude
- Be clear about the units
- Don’t confuse “percent” and “percentage”

Stargazing

Estimates of the relationship between years of schooling and hourly wages

	Males		Females	
	wages	*ln(wages)*	*wages*	*ln(wages)*
Schooling	5.64	.054*	7.83**	.094***
	(5.11)	(.030)	(3.55)	(.007)
Observations	12,385		12,012	

Notes: The sample is restricted to CHAT respondents ages 25-45 from Colorado, Nebraska, and Iowa whose wage was greater than or equal to $3.25 per hour. Each column reports an estimate from a separate OLS regression of wages on years of schooling. Controls include race, ethnicity, marital status, union status, years of experience, tenure at current job, and firm size. Standard errors clustered at the state level are reported in parentheses.

* Statistically significant at the 10% level; ** at the 5% level; *** at the 1% level.

The Standard Error of Regressions

Deirdre N. McCloskey and Stephen T. Ziliak

Journal of Economic Literature
Vol. 34, No. 1 (Mar., 1996), pp. 97-114

Published by: American Economic Association
Stable URL:
http://0-www.jstor.org.skyline.ucdenver.edu/stable/2729411
Page Count: 18

The elementary point that "[t]here is no sharp border between 'significant' and 'insignificant,' only increasingly strong evidence as the p-value decreases" (David S. Moore and George P. McCabe 1993, p. 473)…The old classic by W. Allen Wallis and Harry V. Roberts, Statistics: A New Approach, first published in 1956, is an exception:

> It is essential not to confuse the statistical usage of "significant" with the everyday usage. In everyday usage, "significant" means "of practical importance," or simply "important." (Wallis and Roberts [1956] 1965, p. 385

Magnitude and Significance

OLS estimates of the relationship between years of schooling and ln(wages)

	Insignificant	Significant
BIG	.15 (.131)	.15 (.033)
Small	.0012 (.003)	.0012 (.00001)

Note: Standard errors are reported in parentheses.

OLS estimates of the relationship between years of schooling and ln(wages)

	Insignificant	Significant
BIG	.15 (.131)	.15 (.033)
Small	.0012 (.0033)	.0012 (.00001)

Note: Standard errors are reported in parentheses.

Why would we characterize these estimates as “BIG”? Big relative to what?

OLS estimates of the relationship between years of schooling and ln(wages)

	Insignificant	Significant
BIG	.15 (.131)	.15 (.033)
Small	.0012 (.0033)	.0012 (.00001)

Note: Standard errors are reported in parentheses.

Why would we characterize these estimates as “BIG”? Big relative to what?

1. Relative to previous estimates of the effect of schooling on wages…Cite the most important studies in this area (e.g., Angrist and Krueger 1991) or refer to a “stylized fact”.

Stylized fact

Tools
From Wikipedia, the free encyclopedia

In social sciences, especially economics, a **stylized fact** is a simplified presentation of an empirical finding. Stylized facts are broad tendencies that aim to summarize the data, offering essential truths while ignoring individual details.

OLS estimates of the relationship between years of schooling and ln(wages)

	Insignificant	Significant
BIG	.15 (.131)	.15 (.033)
Small	.0012 (.0033)	.0012 (.00001)

Note: Standard errors are reported in parentheses.

Why would we characterize these estimates as “BIG”? Big relative to what?

2. Relative to the effect of other policies or to an established benchmark/goal. For instance, you could note that, according to your estimate, an additional year of schooling for Blacks would reduce the Black-White wage gap by 4 percentage points.

OLS estimates of the relationship between years of schooling and ln(wages)

	Insignificant	Significant
BIG	.15 (.131)	.15 (.033)
Small	.0012 (.0033)	.0012 (.00001)

Note: Standard errors are reported in parentheses.

Why would we characterize these estimates as “BIG”? Big relative to what?

3. Relative to the mean wage in your sample, or to the change in wages from 1970 to 2015. You’re looking for some way of anchoring the estimate and putting its magnitude into context...

OLS estimates of the relationship between years of schooling and ln(wages)

	Insignificant	Significant
BIG	.15 (.131)	.15 (.033)
Small	.0012 (.0033)	.0012 (.00001)

Note: Standard errors are reported in parentheses.

Why would we characterize these estimates as "small"? Small relative to what?

The above strategies still apply. Often a good idea to point reader to the upper bound of the 95% CI. "Even the upper bound of the 95% CI is small relative to…"

Sometimes you just want to confirm that your estimates are reasonable…

Using data on 19- through 22-year-olds and an RD design, Carpenter and Dobkin (2009) found that reaching the minimum legal drinking age was associated with a 21% increase in alcohol consumption and a 15% increase in traffic fatalities

The implied elasticity of traffic fatalities with respect to alcohol consumption from these estimates is 0.71 (i.e., 0.15/0.21)

Restricting our sample to 19- through 22-year-olds, we (Anderson et al. 2013) found that legalizing medical marijuana was associated with a 15% decrease in alcohol consumption and a 12% decrease in traffic fatalities

The implied elasticity from these estimates is 0.80 (i.e., 0.12/0.15)

References

Anderson, D. Mark, Benjamin Hansen, and Daniel I. Rees. 2013. "Medical Marijuana Laws, Traffic Fatalities, and Alcohol Consumption." *Journal of Law and Economics*, 56 (2): 333-369.

Carpenter, Christopher and Carlos Dobkin. 2009. "The Effect of Alcohol Consumption on Mortality: Regression Discontinuity Evidence from the Minimum Drinking Age." *AEJ: Applied*, 1(1): 164-182.

Table 1. Estimates of the relationship between the unemployment rate and the probability of being vaccinated

Don't report "0.000"   I've even seen 0.000***

	Vaccinated	*Vaccinated*
Unemployment rate	.00005	.005
	(.0006)	(.002)
State FEs	no	yes
Mean of the DV	.266	.266
Observations	12,385	12,012

Notes: Each column reports an estimate from a separate OLS regression of vaccination status (0/1) on years of schooling . Controls include race, ethnicity, marital status, union status, years of experience, tenure at current job, and firm size. Standard errors clustered at the state level are reported in parentheses.

If the unemployment rate goes from 10 to 11 percent, that's a one percentage point increase in the unemployment rate.

The Athletic | NBA Teams Playoff Bracket Scores & Schedule NBA Draft Standings Podcasts ...

Lakers’ LeBron James on his NBA future after win over Nets: ‘I don’t have much time left’

What’s wrong with this sentence?

In his 21st season, James is inexplicably shooting a career-best 41.6 percent on 3s — one percent higher than his previous career-high mark (40.6 percent in 2012-13 with the Miami Heat).

What’s wrong with this sentence?

In his 21st season, James is inexplicably shooting a career-best 41.6 percent on 3s — one percentage point higher than his previous career-high mark (40.6 percent in 2012-13 with the Miami Heat).

Doing Applied Research

Mixtape Track

MIXTAPE SESSIONS

Publishing your work

Basic Steps

1. Produce a working paper

- Present your work (seminars, conferences, brown bags)
- Receive feedback and revise
- Post your work (personal website, SSRN, IZA, NBER)

2. Choose a target journal

- See below

3. Submit

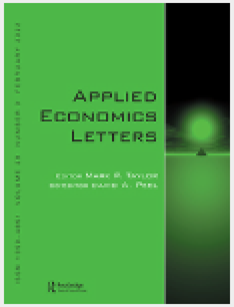
- Upload manuscript and pay submission fee
  – Cover letter?
- Editor will desk reject or assign to a coeditor
  – Coeditor can desk reject or invite referees

4. Wait for the first-round decision

- Desk rejects take anywhere from an hour to a week
- If sent to referees, decision can take a few months to a year
- Decision types:
  – Reject (most common outcome)
  – Revise and resubmit (R&R)
  – Accept (rarely happens)

Choosing a journal

- **I knew NOTHING about journals when I was a grad student**
  - Impact factor (IF)
    - Two-year IF = citations in year *t* to papers published in *t*–1 and *t*–2 ÷ total number of papers published in *t*–1 and *t*–2
      - Two-year IF for 2025 = $\frac{\text{Citations in 2025 to papers published in 2023 and 2024}}{\text{Papers published in 2023 and 2024}}$
    - Can be used to rank journals within—but not across—fields
    - QJE's IF is 5.9
    - JLE's IF is 3.6
    - JEBO's IF is 1.64
    - JAMA's IF is 55!
- **Remember that, at the start of your research project, you read every published paper on…?**
  - Where were the other papers published?
- **Journal rankings are useful, but…**



Applied Economics Letters >

Volume 29, 2022 - Issue 3

Research Article

Top to bottom: an expanded ranking of economics journals

Franklin G. Mixon & Kamal P. Upadhyaya

Pages 226-237 | Published online: 11 Dec 2020

Cite this article https://doi.org/10.1080/13504851.2020.1861198

ABSTRACT

In what we believe is the largest ranking of its kind in economics, this study extends the economics journal ranking literature by examining the impact of papers published in more than 550 economics journals. Based on Google Scholar citations per article to all articles published in the 15-year period from 2001 through 2015, we find that the top five journals are the *American Economic Review*, *Quarterly Journal of Economics*, *Journal of Financial Economics*, *Journal of Political Economy* and *Journal of Economic Perspectives*.

Journal Title	Citations Index	Rank
American Economic Review	100.0000	1
Quarterly Journal of Economics	95.3408	2
Journal Financial Economics	71.8723	3
Journal of Political Economy	52.0459	4
Journal of Economic Perspectives	48.0275	5
Econometrica	46.7287	6
Journal of Monetary Economics	41.9069	7
Review of Economics and Statistics	37.5698	8
Review of Economic Studies	37.1249	9
Journal of Econometrics	30.6026	10
The Economic Journal	30.3943	11
American Economic Journal: Applied Economics	30.2512	12
Journal of Public Economics	30.2324	13
Journal of Economic Literature	29.0611	14
Economic Policy	28.5472	15
Journal of Labor Economics	28.3352	16
Journal of Law and Economics	28.0372	17
⋮		
Journal of the European Economic Association	22.3866	26
Journal of Human Resources	22.1152	27
Journal of Financial and Quantitative Analysis	21.9651	28
Journal of Economic Surveys	20.6812	29
American Economic Journal: Economic Policy	20.1620	30

RANKING DE REVISTAS VIGENTE PARA EL PERIODO 2022-26

PUNTUACIÓN DE LAS CATEGORÍAS

GROUP	**Eigenfactor**	**Eigenfactor Medio E(i)**
A+ (84)	e>=0.04	0,055910
A (36)	0.04>e>=0.02	0,024132
B+ (22)	0.02>e>=0.01	0,014883
B (11)	0.01>e>=0.005	0,007096
C (5)	0.005>e>=0.0025	0,003421
D (3)	0.0025>e>=0.00125	0,001743
E (1)	e<0.00125	0,000560

Full Journal Title	Eigenfactor 2016	2017
AMERICAN ECONOMIC REVIEW	0,113008	0,113669
JOURNAL OF FINANCIAL ECONOMICS	0,064440	0,05771
QUARTERLY JOURNAL OF ECONOMICS	0,051070	0,0558
JOURNAL OF FINANCE	0,056560	0,05172
REVIEW OF FINANCIAL STUDIES	0,051730	0,04477
ECONOMETRICA	0,047050	0,05184
REVIEW OF ECONOMIC STUDIES	0,036010	0,0346
JOURNAL OF POLITICAL ECONOMY	0,024680	0,02627
REVIEW OF ECONOMICS AND STATISTICS	0,032480	0,03012
JOURNAL OF ECONOMETRICS	0,027610	0,02669
WORLD DEVELOPMENT	0,019880	0,02059
JOURNAL OF ECONOMIC PERSPECTIVES	0,025550	0,02171
ECONOMIC JOURNAL	0,022510	0,02075
ENERGY ECONOMICS	0,021170	0,02123
JOURNAL OF PUBLIC ECONOMICS	0,022640	0,02049
American Economic Journal-Applied Economics	0,021990	0,01802

THE ECONOMIC JOURNAL

The Economic Journal, **136** (*January*), 259–278 https://doi.org/10.1093/ej/ueaf044
Advance Access Publication Date: 18 June 2025

THE DRAMATIC RISE OF THE NEW SOCIETY JOURNALS IN ECONOMICS*

John C. Ham, Julian Wright and Ziqiu Ye

We produce updated rankings of economics journals based on established and new methodologies, and use these rankings to document the spectacular rise of the new society journals in economics. We show that, while several factors (editor reputations, editor experience, citations from parent journals and the number of articles published) help determine these journals' impact factors, none help explain why the new journals outperform natural comparison journals. However, soliciting top authors connected to the editors can explain their outperformance. We also consider factors such as fast turnaround times, the transfer of referee reports and associations leveraging their reputations.

JEL codes: A11, A14, C23, J44

Table 1. *Rankings of Baseline Journals across Alternative Methods.*

Journal	Invariant method	Removal of reference intensity	Top-five method	Invariant top-five method
Quarterly Journal of Economics	1	1	1	1
American Economic Review	2	2	4	2
Econometrica	3	5	3	4
Review of Economic Studies	4	4	5	5
Journal of Political Economy	5	3	2	3
American Economic Journal: Applied Economics	6	6	7	6
American Economic Journal: Macroeconomics	7	7	6	7
American Economic Journal: Economic Policy	8	9	10	9
Journal of Labor Economics	9	10	12	11
American Economic Review: Insights	10	8	8	8
Journal of The European Economic Association	11	11	11	12
Review of Economics and Statistics	12	12	14	14
Theoretical Economics	13	14	9	10
Journal of Human Resources	14	15	18	18
Journal of Monetary Economics	15	13	16	16
American Economic Journal: Microeconomics	16	16	13	13
Quantitative Economics	17	17	15	15
Economic Journal	18	18	22	21

Journal of Economic Growth	19	19	21	22
RAND Journal of Economics	20	20	17	17
Journal of Business & Economic Statistics	21	24	27	28
Review of Economic Dynamics	22	21	19	20
Journal of International Economics	23	22	23	23
Journal of Public Economics	24	23	25	25
Journal of Economic Theory	25	25	20	19
International Economic Review	26	26	24	24
Journal of Econometrics	27	29	29	27
Journal of Applied Econometrics	28	32	46	46
Journal of Development Economics	29	27	26	26
Econometric Theory	30	41	42	42
Experimental Economics	31	30	36	35
Econometrics Journal	32	43	38	43
IMF Economic Review	33	28	28	29
Journal of the Association of Environmental and Resource Economists	34	31	39	48
Games and Economic Behavior	35	34	30	30
European Economic Review	36	33	43	37
Journal of Urban Economics	37	35	41	40
Journal of Money Credit and Banking	38	39	52	51
Journal of Health Economics	39	38	53	45
Economic Theory	40	48	49	49
Journal of Economic History	41	36	32	31
Journal of Law & Economics	42	37	33	32
Journal of Policy Analysis and Management	43	40	51	55
Journal of Industrial Economics	44	45	35	34
Journal of Risk and Uncertainty	45	50	48	52
Economica	46	42	45	38
Economic Development and Cultural Change	47	44	44	44
Journal of Financial Econometrics	48	65	69	62
Scandinavian Journal of Economics	49	51	73	67
Journal of Law Economics & Organization	50	47	40	39
Journal of Environmental Economics and Management	51	53	66	64
Explorations in Economic History	52	49	37	33

Aim high?

- **Begin by aiming high**
  - I will take one or two shots at "reach journals"
    - For instance, I will send my paper to an AEJ even though the likely outcome is rejection
  - Are you in a rush?
    - Some journals are notoriously slow
    - Some journals report average time to decision on their website
    - Journals have reputations. Ask.
      - ReStat is likely going to take longer than an AEJ
      - QJE can be lightening fast
      - JPE can be glacially slow

Journal	Desk rejections (%)	Expected wait time conditional on referee review (days)	Median wait time conditional on referee review (days)
Quarterly J of Economics	66	45	41
American Economic Review	46	92	79
J of Political Economy	49	120	92
AEJ: Applied	45	82	81
AEJ: Micro	38	135	120
Economic Journal	55	107	92

(https://jcsuarez.shinyapps.io/journal_turnaround_app/)

Rejections happen

- **Rejections happen (more often than not)**
  - Try to stay positive and receptive
    - Are all the referees raising the same issue?
    - Did the referees misunderstand and/or misinterpret something you thought was crystal clear?

- **Take multiple shots on goal**
  - Do not give up too quickly!
    - Luck is just as important as the quality of your work
      - Did you draw an editor who is interested in your research topic?
      - Did you draw a referee who woke up on the wrong side of the bed?
      - Did you draw a referee with a conflict of interest?
      - Did you draw a referee who knows you from a conference or a seminar?

Example of the process

- We produced a working paper, **“The Effects of Becoming a Physician on Prescription Drug Use”** (Mark Anderson, Ron Diris, Raymond Montizaan and Daniel Rees, NBER WP No. 29536)
  - Bullet-proof causal identification based on a lottery that determined admissions into Dutch medical schools
  - We could not identify the mechanism (burnout vs. access)
  - It is arguably too narrow a question for a general-interest journal

- Given these shortcomings, we decided against sending to a top-5 journal or an AEJ

- We tried ReStat and EJ
  - Referees at both journals recommended rejection
    - Every referee wanted to know more about mechanisms
  - Decided not to waste our time at places like JEEA, JPubE, etc.
  - Received constructive reports at JHE
  - Had we been rejected at the JHE, we would have dropped down to second-tier field journals

Doing Applied Research

Mixtape Track

MIXTAPE SESSIONS

You have referee reports. Now what?

- Rejection
  - Do not email the editor.
    The editor does not want or expect an email acknowledging the rejection.
  - Wait a few days before emailing the editor. Appeals can occasionally elicit a response and reassessment.
    - Some journals have a formal appeals process
  - Think about revising the paper. If the reports sound similar (if the same issue is raised by each and every referee), then do your very best to revise the paper.

- Rejection
  - Look for easily addressed comments.
    There is some chance that you will draw the same referee at the next journal to which you submit.
    - Referees do **NOT** have to recuse themselves if they've provided comments on your paper to another journal.
    - If your research question is narrow, there is a good chance that you will draw the same referee again and again.

- Congratulations! You have an R&R
  - Do not email the editor. The editor does not want or expect an email acknowledging the decision.
  - If you hit a roadblock in the revision process, you might consider emailing the editor
  - Read the decision letter carefully.
    - I will often explicitly invite authors to contact me if they run into a roadblock
    - A good editor will give you direction. She will tell you what to focus on and clearly point you to the most pressing issues.
    - Other editors will not give you any direction. They will likely leave the final decision to the referees.
    - If editor does not give direction, then you are engaging directly with the referees and the editor is, in all likelihood, going to blindly follow their recommendations.

To resubmit, you'll need to do the following:

1. Revise your paper
2. Write a letter to the editor
3. Write point-by-point responses to the reviewer comments

Your goal when writing letter and responding to comments is to sound responsive!

Letter to the Editor

Dear Dr. ________,

Thank you for the opportunity to revise our paper, "Terror Attacks and Election Outcomes in Europe" (MS# 4662). In response to your comments and those of the reviewers, we have made several substantial changes to the paper:

- The effects of terror attacks occurring 2-3 months before an election are now examined in Section 2.1. Reviewer 2 suggested that this analysis be included in a separate...
- In response to a comment made by Reviewer 1, we restructured…
- Although we could not obtain data on the number of fatalities per month, we were able to…
- We now include "back-of-the-envelope" estimates of the cost to society from allowing…

Our point-by-point responses to the comments of the reviewers are below. We have bolded and italicized their comments.

Point-by-point responses to Reviewer 1

3. Another issue is the type of terror attacks is not documented. The effect of an Islamic terror attack is probably very different than an attack by a left-wing terrorist group, don't you think?

In response to this comment, we now include a list of all known groups that committed terror attacks during the period under study. There are more than 100 terrorist groups on this list, 13 of which can be labeled Islamic.

Making distinctions between European terrorist groups based on their political orientation on a left-right scale proved to be difficult, but we now examine effects of terror attacks perpetrated by Islamic terrorist groups versus terror attacks perpetrated by non-Islamic groups…

- The goal is to sound responsive!
- Be clear about what you were able to do (and what you couldn’t do)
- Always try to do something, even if it’s not precisely what the referee is asking for.

It is often useful to repeat or rephrase a comment. Try to put some structure on vague comments.

4. It would be useful to run the regressions over different time periods and see how well the results hold. Similarly, a south dummy might be useful, since the South had fewer hospitals and more blacks…

As attitudes, physician training and medical technology evolved, middle- and upper-class women increasingly chose to give birth in hospitals during the period under study. This trend accelerated markedly after 1920 (Wertz and Wertz 1989). In Appendix Table 5, we provide pre- and post-1920 estimates of the effect of licensing on maternal mortality.

If the state fixed effects are replaced with region dummies (i.e., an indicator for South, an indicator for Midwest, etc.), the negative association between maternal mortality and the licensing of midwives remains...

If the referee is wrong or misinformed, avoid pointing it out. Try to work around it.

Do not make referees hunt for your new estimates. Put new and updated results in the point-by-point responses. You can put tables or figures in the point-by-point responses.

The table below reports the results from Table 2 with p-values calculated from the wild cluster bootstrap technique for comparison. In general, inference changes little when bootstrapping.

Results from Table 2 and wild cluster bootstrapped p-values

	(1)	(2)	(3)	(4)	(5)
Midwifery License Required	-.076**	-.067**	-.068**	-.081***	-.086***
	(.037)	(.028)	(.028)	(.024)	(.024)
p-value from wild cluster bootstrapping	.052	.027	.032	.002	.001

Notes: Bootstrapping was performed over 1,000 replications.

Referees, of course, can be negative. Often, you will disagree with a suggestion and want to avoid implementing it.

1. The paper also seems to be changing **focus** ***from one issue to another without a clear thought process about whether the focus is on bullying victimization, suicide behaviors, depression or LGB.***

The rest of the report read like a detailed guide to restructuring our paper, which we did not want to do. Because the editor was engaged, we decided to push back. Probably not a good idea if the editor is not engaged!

How long should you wait before resubmitting?

- Major revision
  - Check to see if there is a deadline
    - Not all journals set a deadline. Editors can alter the deadline.
    - Medical journals have very short deadlines (≤ 1 month)
  - Even if there is no deadline, try to resubmit within six months
    - If the revision is going to take longer than a year, consider emailing the editor and letting her know

- Minor revision
  - Check to see if there is a deadline
  - Even if there is no deadline, try to resubmit quickly (within a few weeks?)

Doing Applied Research

Mixtape Track

Mixtape Sessions

Writing a referee report

When should you decline a request to referee?

- Do you know the author(s)?
  - Can you be objective?
  - How close is your relationship with the author?
    - At the JHR, being reviewed by a co-author is associated with a 21% increase in the likelihood of a positive recommendation (Carrell et al. 2022)
  - Email the editor and ask for direction
  - Alternatively, get your report back quickly and let the editor know that you have a relationship with an author

Reference

Carrell, Scott E., David N. Figlio, and Lester R. Lusher. 2022. “Clubs and Networks in Economics Reviewing.” NBER WP No. 29631.

When should you decline a request to referee?

- Have you refereed this manuscript before?
  - Email the editor and ask for direction
  - Alternatively, get your report back quickly and let the editor know that you’ve reviewed the paper before
  - Has the manuscript changed?
    - If authors have addressed your comments, it’s ok to recommend “accept as is.”

When should you decline a request to referee?

- Do you have a competing working paper?
  - E-mail the editor and ask for direction
  - Alternatively, get your report back quickly and let the editor know that you have a competing paper. Carefully describe the overlap between the two papers.
  - Is your working paper cited?
    - How long has your working paper been available?
    - Is your working paper described accurately?

Your report

- Begin report with a quick summary
  - Describe, data source, ID strategy, main findings
- What is the bottom line?
  - Describe the importance of the contribution and shortcomings

Your report

- Number your points
  - Numbering provides structure/guidance
    - Major comments questions, and suggestions
    - Minor comments, questions, and suggestions
    - Essential vs. optional suggestions?
- Be constructive
  - Your job is not to impress the editor
  - Ask if you're not certain
  - Try not to stargaze

Your report

- Try to keep the report to one or two pages
  - If you are recommending revisions, your report will usually be longer than if you are recommending rejection
    - In general, 5-page reports are useless

Your report

- You are writing with two audiences in mind
  - Provide enough background so that the editor can understand your major points. Remember, the editor probably has not read the paper carefully.
    - You're trying to persuade the editor, not the author(s)
    - If you're writing a positive report, keep in mind that another referee is almost certainly writing a negative report. Be clear about why you like the paper.
    - If you're writing a negative report, try to put yourself in the author's shoes. Be clear, but not gratuitously negative or pedantic.
  - Some comments, suggestions, and questions can be directed to the author(s). You can assume an intimate knowledge of the methodology and institutional details.

Negative but constructive

In Table 4, the authors split the sample based on the gender of the instructor. Unfortunately, they run into power issues. In columns (1) and (2) of Table 4, neither of the δ estimates is statistically significant and the estimates of γ (the effect of being assigned a female TA) are not distinguishable from each other in a statistical sense…

On page 18, the authors make this argument, but I am skeptical given the power issues referred to above. Would it be possible to collect more data? With more data, the authors might be able to convincingly...

Positive and constructive

The authors identification strategy is clever and the research question is of first-order importance, although…

1. The empirical setup is a standard DD (and then a DDD) regression model. However, instead of using an indicator (ban vs. no ban), the author uses an index that is intended to capture the strictness/intensity of the smoking ban. The index involves weighting the four different types of bans by the number of workers by establishment type (e.g., workers in bars, restaurants, small pubs, dancing clubs, party tents). My preference would be to start by showing the results of DD and DDD regression models that use a simple ban vs. no ban indicator…

Doing Applied Research

Mixtape Track

Giving an effective seminar

General tips

- Presenting is 50% entertainment and 50% teaching
  - Teach your audience something new — anything new — and they will remember you
    - Ask them questions
    - Engage with your audience
  - Show them that you are passionate about research

General tips

- If you're overly technical and aim your presentation at a narrow audience, then your presentation will be forgotten
- Think about aiming your presentation at the person in the audience **LEAST** familiar with your area of research

The power of stories

“Telling Stories with Data
- A Systematic Review”

Schröder, Kay, Wiebke Eberhardt, Poornima Belavadi, Batoul Ajdadilish, Nanette van Haften, Ed Overes, Taryn Brouns, and André Calero Valdez

“Data without context is meaningless; for data to have an impact, it requires a story.”

—Schröder et al.(2023)

The power of stories

- During your seminar, you're going to present more information than anyone can possibly remember
- Think of yourself as a storyteller
  - Numbers and facts w/o context are difficult to remember
  - Stories are easy to remember
  - Your story is the scaffolding upon which you fasten numbers and facts

Your story is the scaffolding upon which you fasten numbers and facts

How to effectively convey your story

- Limit what you present. **Less is more**.
- Prime your listeners
  - Briefly describe your ID strategy early in your presentation
  - Preview your main results
  - What comes next? What's on the next slide? What is the goal of the next section?
    - "Next, I am going to try to convince you of X…It's important that I convince you of X, because…"

Why do we use slides?

- Don’t use slides to “prove” that you’ve read every paper on…
- Don’t use slides to “prove” you did 27 separate robustness checks
  - Don’t use slides to show descriptive statistics and/or coefficients for each and every variable in your analysis

Why do we use slides?

- Prompts for you
  - Numbers that you do not want to memorize
  - Specific language/phrasing that you might forget
- Visual aids for your audience
  - Figures are, in general, better than tables
  - Each slide should convey one main point. **Less is more.**
  - Your audience will tune out if you try to present too much on one slide

What should be on your slide?

- Try for three lines on each slide
  - At most one or two sub-points under each line
- Keep your language simple
  - Avoid using jargon
  - Avoid using too many acronyms
    - “We explore the heterogenous effects of NOTDA and/or YATES exposure by…” **Yuk!!!**
- Keep your slides clean and easy to read

- Pregnant women constitute one of the most vulnerable sub-groups in these communities.
- In utero exposure to maternal stress may have adverse effects on infant health (Black et al., 2016; Persson and Rossin-Slater, 2018b).
- Short term implications:
    - 20 times higher IMR for (VLBW) babies (NCHS, 2016).
    - Two-thirds of all infant deaths in 2016 occurred to infants who were born premature (NCHS, 2016).
- Long term implications:
    - Poor health as young adulthood (Oreopoulos et al. 2008; Currie et al. 2010).
    - Permanent Income (Bharadwaj et al. 2017).
    - Cognitive development (Figlio et al. 2014).
    - Completed years of education (Royer 2009).
    - IQ, earnings, labor market (Black et al. 2007; Oreopoulos et al. 2008).

This slide is from a seminar I attended in the fall.

Clean? Easy to read?

- Pregnant women constitute one of the most vulnerable sub-groups in these communities.
- In utero exposure to maternal stress may have adverse effects on infant health (Black et al., 2016; Persson and Rossin-Slater, 2018b).
- Short term implications:
  - 20 times higher IMR for (VLBW) babies (NCHS, 2016).
  - Two-thirds of all infant deaths in 2016 occurred to infants who were born premature (NCHS, 2016).
- Long term implications:
  - Poor health as young adulthood (Oreopoulos et al. 2008; Currie et al. 2010).
  - Permanent Income (Bharadwaj et al. 2017).
  - Cognitive development (Figlio et al. 2014).
  - Completed years of education (Royer 2009).
  - IQ, earnings, labor market (Black et al. 2007; Oreopoulos et al. 2008).

Clean? Easy to read?

- Pregnant women constitute one of the most vulnerable sub-groups in these communities.
- In utero exposure to maternal stress may have adverse effects on infant health (Black et al., 2016; Persson and Rossin-Slater, 2018b).
- Short term implications:
  - 20 times higher IMR for (VLBW) babies (NCHS, 2016).
  - Two-thirds of all infant deaths in 2016 occurred to infants who were born premature (NCHS, 2016).
- Long term implications:
  - Poor health as young adulthood (Oreopoulos et al. 2008; Currie et al. 2010).
  - Permanent Income (Bharadwaj et al. 2017).
  - Cognitive development (Figlio et al. 2014).
  - Completed years of education (Royer 2009).
  - IQ, earnings, labor market (Black et al. 2007; Oreopoulos et al. 2008).

Your introduction

- The first five minutes are the most important
- Talk about yourself with the title slide up
  - How did you become interested in this topic?
  - Why did this topic engage you?
  - This is a chance to create your brand
    - Every talk is a job talk…
- Begin with the “big picture”
  - Why should we care about this general topic?

Your introduction

- Don’t get bogged down in the previous literature
  - You do not need to cite each and every paper ever published on your topic
    - “Previous work on minimum wages has been done by Smith (1884), Ashenfelter and Krueger (1994), Percy (1996), Samuels et al. (1998), Pope et al. (1998), Sabia and Hansen (2001)…” **Yuk!!!**
- Be clear about your contribution
  - Do not overreach
    - “I contribute to five different literatures…” **Yuk!!!**
- Be enthusiastic!

Background

- Remember, most audience members are not specialists in this area. You know more than they do.
  - This is a chance to teach them something new
- Try to briefly characterize the state of the literature
  - What do we know and what don’t we know?
  - Show that you’re an expert in this field, broadly defined

Background

- At the end of the background section, come back to your contribution
  - You can be more specific now
    - “Aside from Currie et al. (2004), previous researchers have not…I build upon Currie et al. (2004) by…

Your data

- Collecting unique or difficult-to-find data is rewarded by the profession

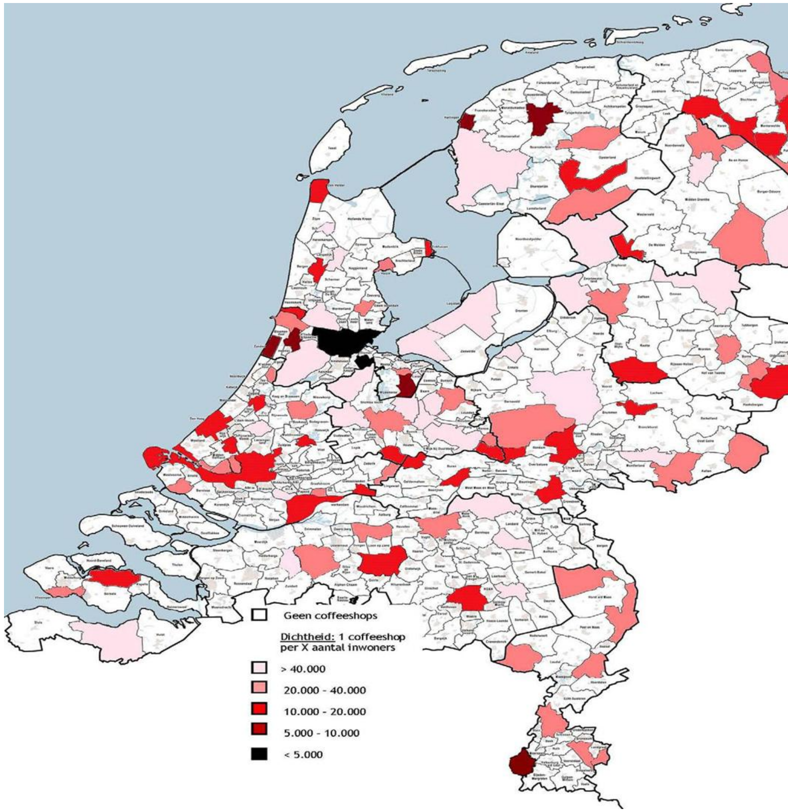
- Spend some time talking about your data
  - Don’t be humble!

Avoid showing a long table full of descriptive statistics

Variables	Mean	SD	N
Female homicides per 100,000	0.13	0.39	54,424
Male prostitution arrests per 100,000	1.00	3.72	68,513
Female prostitution arrests per 100,000	1.79	5.22	68,513
Female rape offenses per 100,000	2.93	4.02	47,904
Burglary offenses per 100,000	87.25	110.63	47,904
Total reviews	42.47	92.78	8,113
Total providers	8.44	16.77	8,113
Craigslist email	0.002	0.04	68,450
Independent	0.56	0.50	68,450
Agency	0.34	0.47	68,450
Incall	0.84	0.36	68,450
Hourly price	$294.33	173.51	344,399
Screening	0.05	0.22	344,561
Repeat	0.15	0.37	344,561
Looks rating	7.46	0.98	344,561
Performance rating	7.32	1.42	344,561
Street	0.02	0.14	344,561
Female homicides from acquaintance killer per 100,000	0.03	0.13	54,272
Male homicides per 100,000	0.50	0.83	54,272
Manslaughters per 100,000	0.01	0.14	51,168

Your data

- Often, you can use a figure or map to introduce the data to your audience
  - Talk about trends and their importance
    - Can you say something here about your identification strategy or maybe potential threats to identification?
    - You want to be the one who first mentions an obvious threats to identification
  - Briefly define your key variables



Tables

- Don’t show estimates that you’re not going to talk about

- Go through your columns one by one

- Pay attention to the units
  - Is that a percentage point change? Is that a percent change?

- Try to mention magnitude

- Take your time!
  - Leave enough time to savior your results
    - We’ll talk about handling questions in a few slides

	(1) Birthweight	(2) Low Birthweight	(3) Premature	(4) Any Conditions At Birth Newborn	(5) Prepregnancy Hypertension	(6) C-Section	(7) Induction of Labor
Panel A:							
1st Trimester x 10m	-11.063	0.904**	-0.432	0.705*	0.113	-0.791	-0.003
	(6.810)	(0.384)	(0.399)	(0.412)	(0.234)	(0.955)	(0.010)
2nd Trimester x 10m	-38.737***	0.947**	0.622	0.328	0.435***	0.430	0.002
	(10.235)	(0.461)	(0.472)	(0.360)	(0.144)	(0.682)	(0.013)
3rd Trimester x 10m	-11.224	0.110	-0.757	0.204	0.385**	0.776	0.017**
	(13.354)	(0.506)	(0.713)	(0.254)	(0.178)	(0.824)	(0.008)
Panel B:							
Exposure to Shootings During Pregnancy x 10m	-20.118***	0.645***	-0.201	0.410*	0.311**	0.144	0.006
	(5.937)	(0.239)	(0.268)	(0.244)	(0.155)	(0.511)	(0.009)
Mean DV	3334.245	7.038	9.667	4.487	0.772	16.681	0.198
Conception Day-Month-Year FE	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes
County FE	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes
Mother/Child Characteristics	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes
County Specific Linear Trends	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes
Observations	265,200	265,200	265,377	265,003	265,377	265,344	265,377

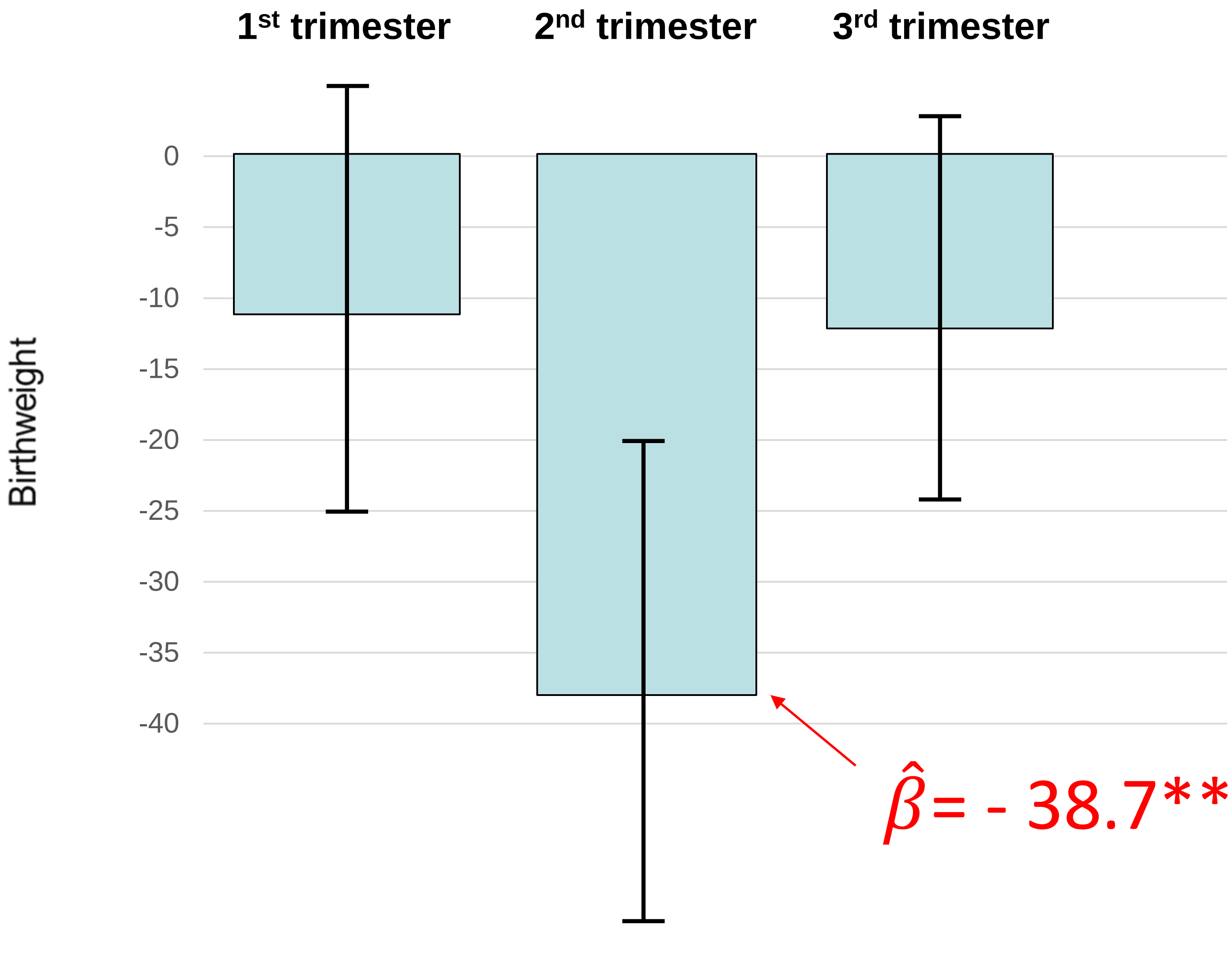
This table is from a seminar I attended in the fall.
What can be improved?

	(1) Birthweight	(2) Low Birthweight	(3) Premature	(4) Any Conditions At Birth Newborn	(5) Prepregnancy Hypertension	(6) C-Section	(7) Induction of Labor
Panel A:							
1st Trimester x 10m	-11.063	0.904**	-0.432	0.705*	0.113	-0.791	-0.003
	(6.810)	(0.384)	(0.399)	(0.412)	(0.234)	(0.955)	(0.010)
2nd Trimester x 10m	-38.737***	0.947**	0.622	0.328	0.435***	0.430	0.002
	(10.235)	(0.461)	(0.472)	(0.360)	(0.144)	(0.682)	(0.013)
3rd Trimester x 10m	-11.224	0.110	-0.757	0.204	0.385**	0.776	0.017**
	(13.354)	(0.506)	(0.713)	(0.254)	(0.178)	(0.824)	(0.008)
Panel B:							
Exposure to Shootings During	-20.118***	0.645***	-0.201	0.410*	0.311**	0.144	0.006
Pregnancy x 10m	(5.937)	(0.239)	(0.268)	(0.244)	(0.155)	(0.511)	(0.009)
Mean DV	3334.245	7.038	9.667	4.487	0.772	16.681	0.198
Conception Day-Month-Year FE	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes
County FE	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes
Mother/Child Characteristics	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes
County Specific Linear Trends	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes
Observations	265,200	265,200	265,377	265,003	265,377	265,344	265,377

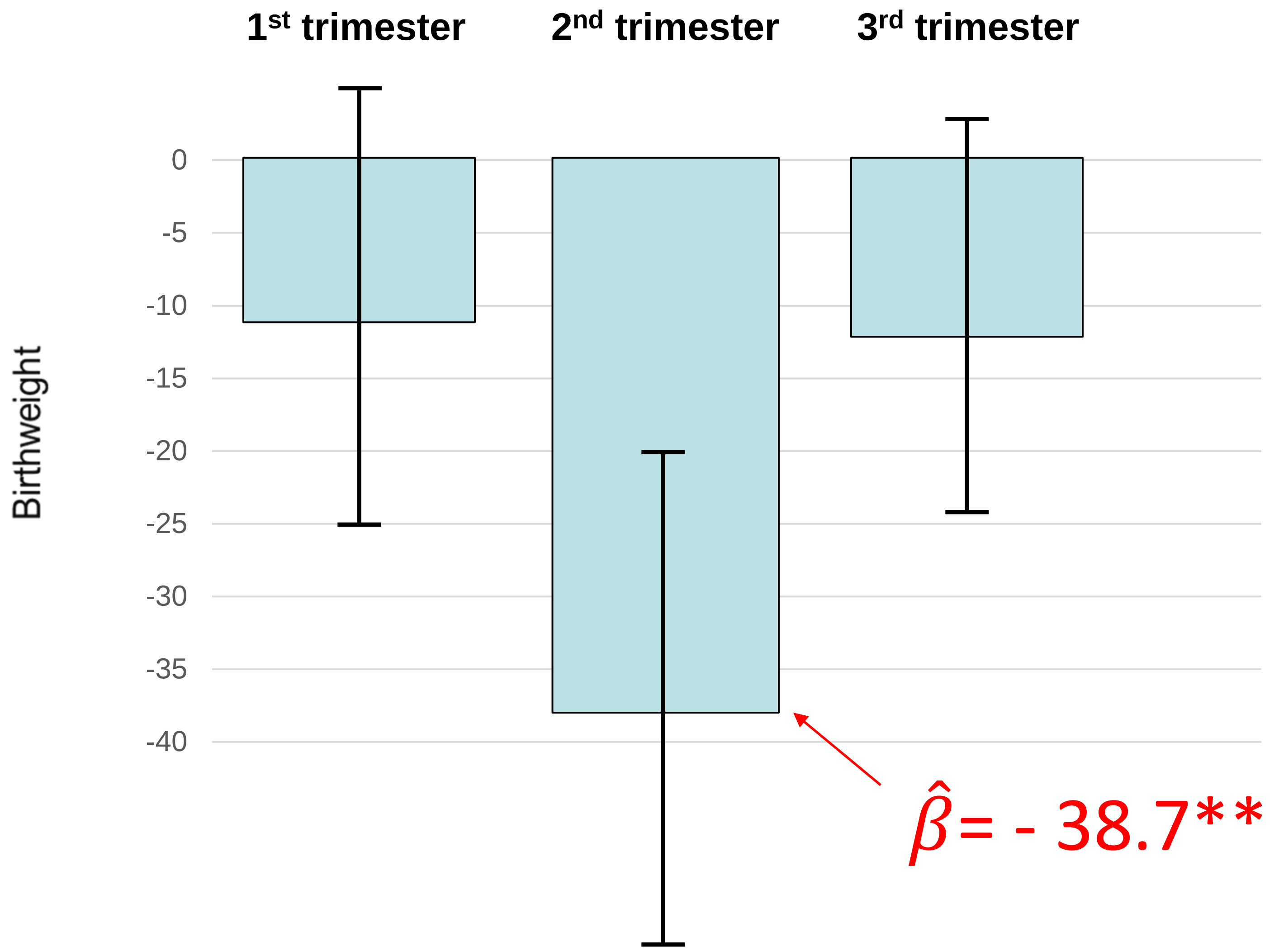
This is what it looked like from the back of the room.

	(1) Birthweight	(2) Low Birthweight	(3) Premature	(4) Any Conditions At Birth Newborn	(5) Prepregnancy Hypertension	(6) C-Section	(7) Induction of Labor
Panel A:							
1st Trimester x 10m	-11.063	0.904**	-0.432	0.705*	0.113	-0.791	-0.003
	(6.810)	(0.384)	(0.399)	(0.412)	(0.234)	(0.955)	(0.010)
2nd Trimester x 10m	-38.737***	0.947**	0.622	0.328	0.435***	0.430	0.002
	(10.235)	(0.461)	(0.472)	(0.360)	(0.144)	(0.682)	(0.013)
3rd Trimester x 10m	-11.224	0.110	-0.757	0.204	0.385**	0.776	0.017**
	(13.354)	(0.506)	(0.713)	(0.254)	(0.178)	(0.824)	(0.008)
Panel B:							
Exposure to Shootings During Pregnancy x 10m	-20.118***	0.645***	-0.201	0.410*	0.311**	0.144	0.006
	(5.937)	(0.239)	(0.268)	(0.244)	(0.155)	(0.511)	(0.009)
Mean DV	3334.245	7.038	9.667	4.487	0.772	16.681	0.198
Conception Day-Month-Year FE	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes
County FE	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes
Mother/Child Characteristics	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes
County Specific Linear Trends	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes
Observations	265,200	265,200	265,377	265,003	265,377	265,344	265,377

What can be improved?


1st trimester
2nd trimester
3rd trimester
Birthweight
0
-5
-10
-15
-20
-25
-30
-35
-40
$\hat{\beta}$= - 38.7**

Mention magnitude. You can say that, "in a few slides I will argue that -38.7, although statistically significant, is trivially small."



Municipal Anti-TB Measures and ln(Pulmonary TB Mortality)

	(1)	(2)	(3)
Total # of Municipal Anti-TB Measures	-.003 (.008)		
Any Municipal Anti-TB Measure			
1 Municipal Anti-TB Measure			
2 Municipal Anti-TB Measures			
3+ Municipal Anti-TB Measures			

This estimate is small…

Notes: All models control for the municipal demographics characteristics and state anti-TB measures listed in Table 1, municipality fixed effects, year fixed effects, and municipality-specific linear trends. Regressions are weighted by municipality population. Standard errors, corrected for clustering at the state level, are in parentheses. N = 7,439 (548 municipalities).

Municipal Anti-TB Measures and ln(Pulmonary TB Mortality)

	(1)	(2)	(3)
Total # of Municipal Anti-TB Measures	-.003 (.008)		
Any Municipal Anti-TB Measure		.025 (.020)	
1 Municipal Anti-TB Measure			
2 Municipal Anti-TB Measures			
3+ Municipal Anti-TB Measures			

This estimate is larger, but in the "wrong" direction…

Notes: All models control for the municipal demographics characteristics and state anti-TB measures listed in Table 1, municipality fixed effects, year fixed effects, and municipality-specific linear trends. Regressions are weighted by municipality population. Standard errors, corrected for clustering at the state level, are in parentheses. N = 7,439 (548 municipalities).

Municipal Anti-TB Measures and ln(Pulmonary TB Mortality)

	(1)	(2)	(3)
Total # of Municipal Anti-TB Measures	.003 (.008)		
Any Municipal Anti-TB Measure		.025 (.020)	
1 Municipal Anti-TB Measure			.005 (.008)
2 Municipal Anti-TB Measures			-.014 (.031)
3+ Municipal Anti-TB Measures			-.007 (.022)

We find consistently small, statistically insignificant estimates

Notes: All models control for the municipal demographics characteristics and state anti-TB measures listed in Table 1, municipality fixed effects, year fixed effects, and municipality-specific linear trends. Regressions are weighted by municipality population. Standard errors, corrected for clustering at the state level, are in parentheses. N = 7,439 (548 municipalities).

- Figures are, in general, better than tables
  - This is true for your papers too
- Prime your audience for the figure before you show it

Contents lists available at ScienceDirect

Journal of Public Economics

journal homepage: www.elsevier.com/locate/jpube

“Rugged individualism” and collective (in)action during the COVID-19 pandemic ☆

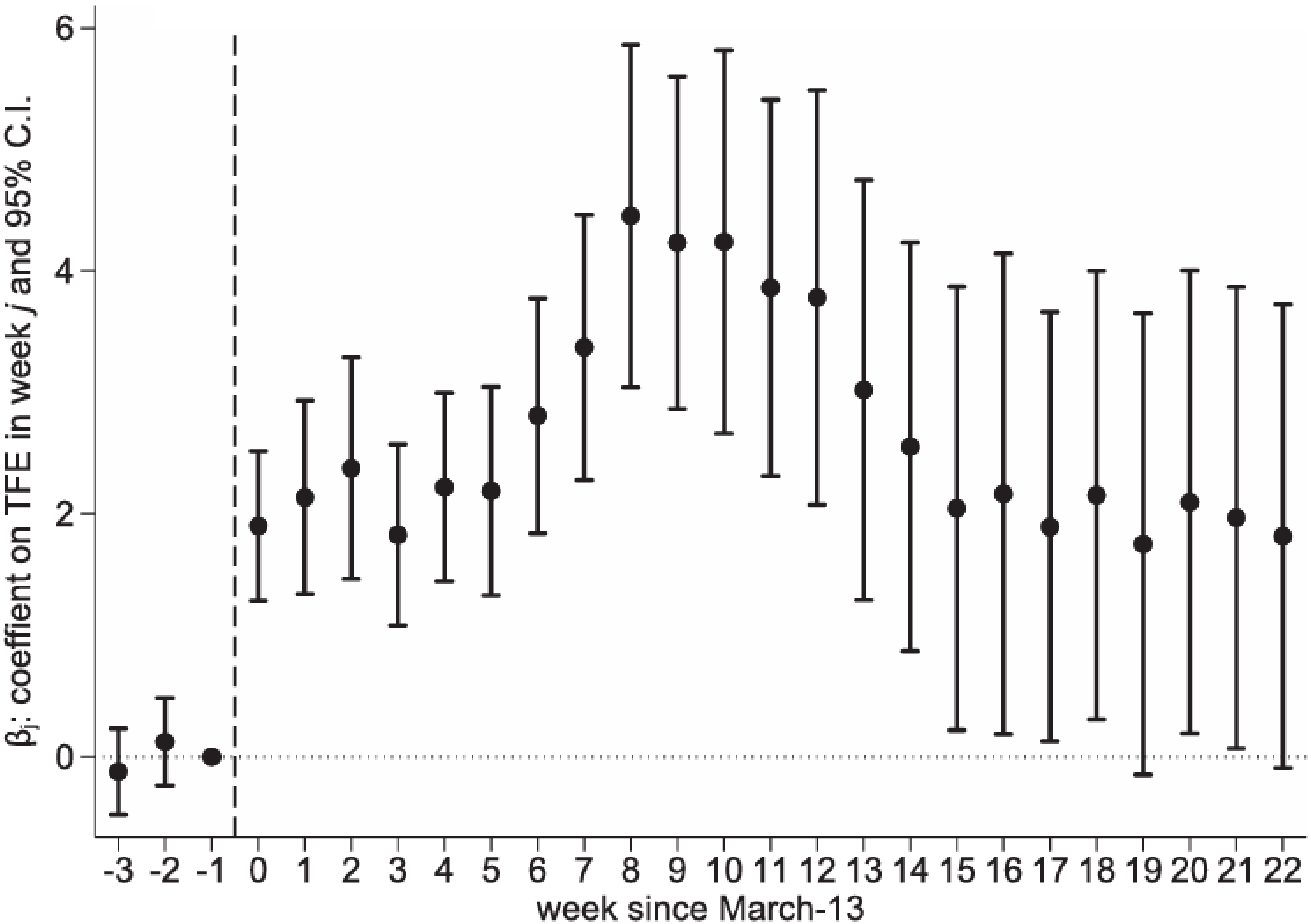
Samuel Bazzi [a,b,c,1], Martin Fiszbein [b,e,2], Mesay Gebresilasse [d,3]

Abstract

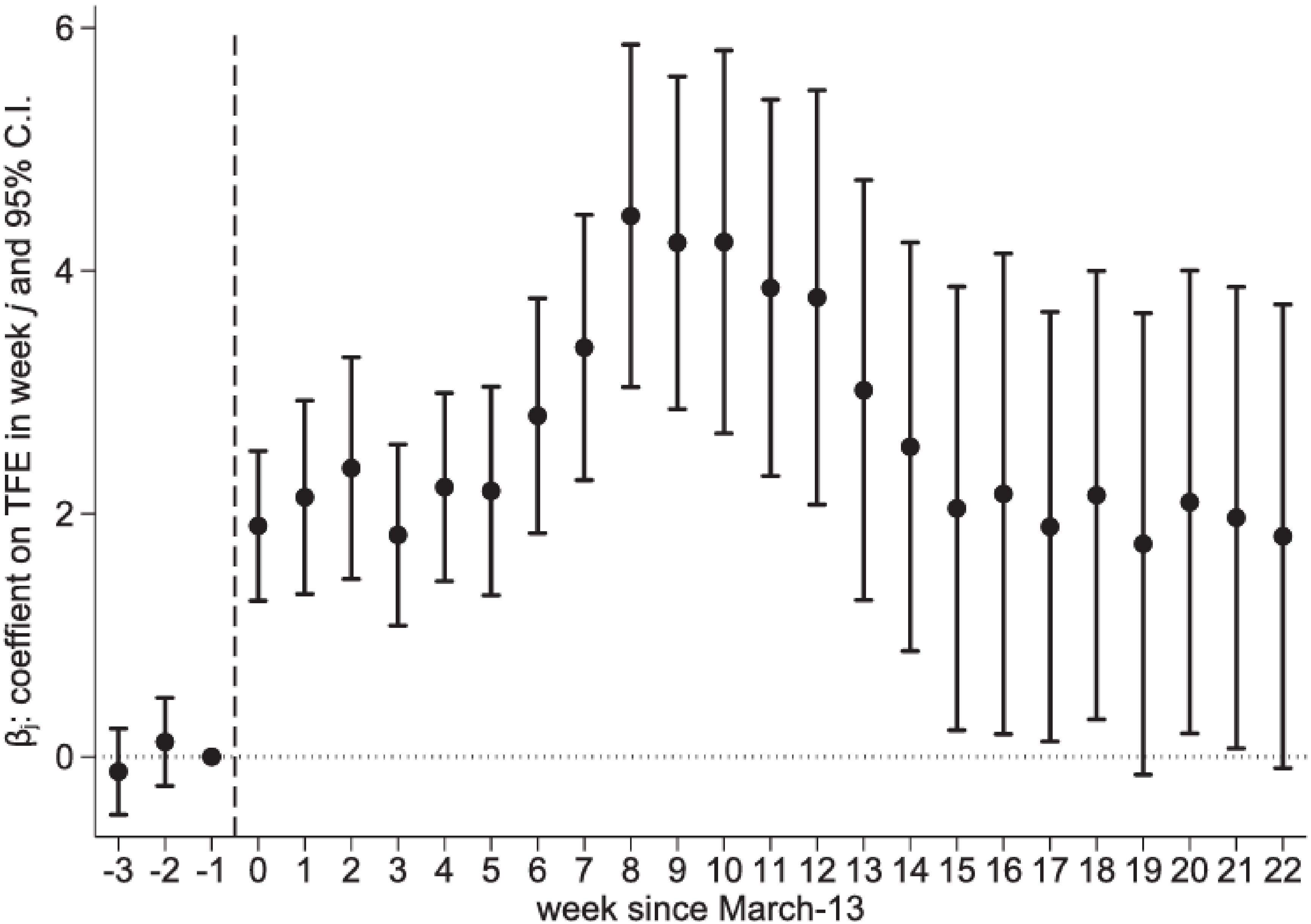
“Rugged individualism” is a prominent feature of American culture with deep roots in the country’s history of frontier settlement. Today, rugged individualism is more prevalent in counties with greater total frontier experience (**TFE**) during the era of westward expansion…

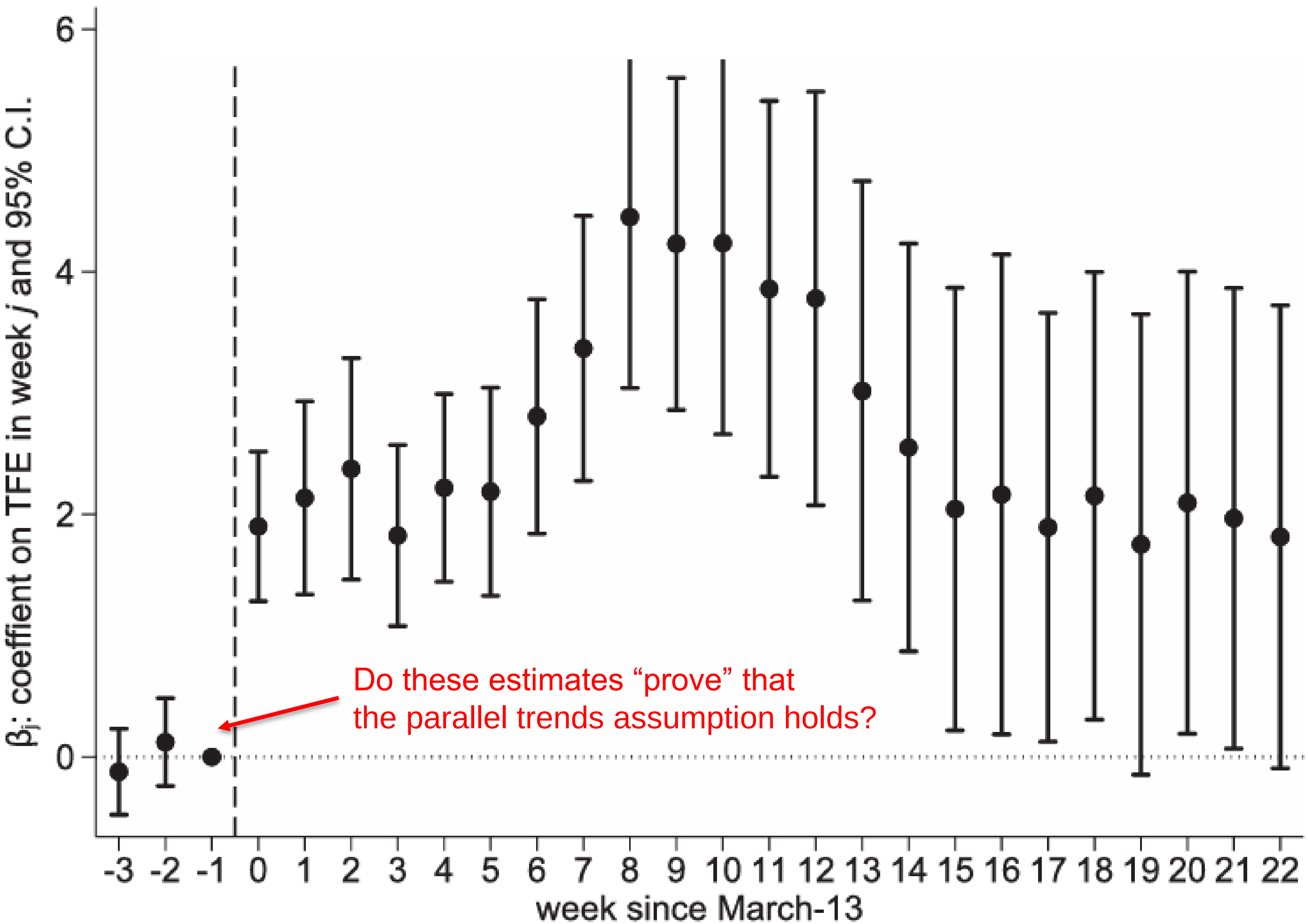
Next, I’m going to show you event studies from Bazzi et al. (2021)…

Slow down! Explain what's on the axes.

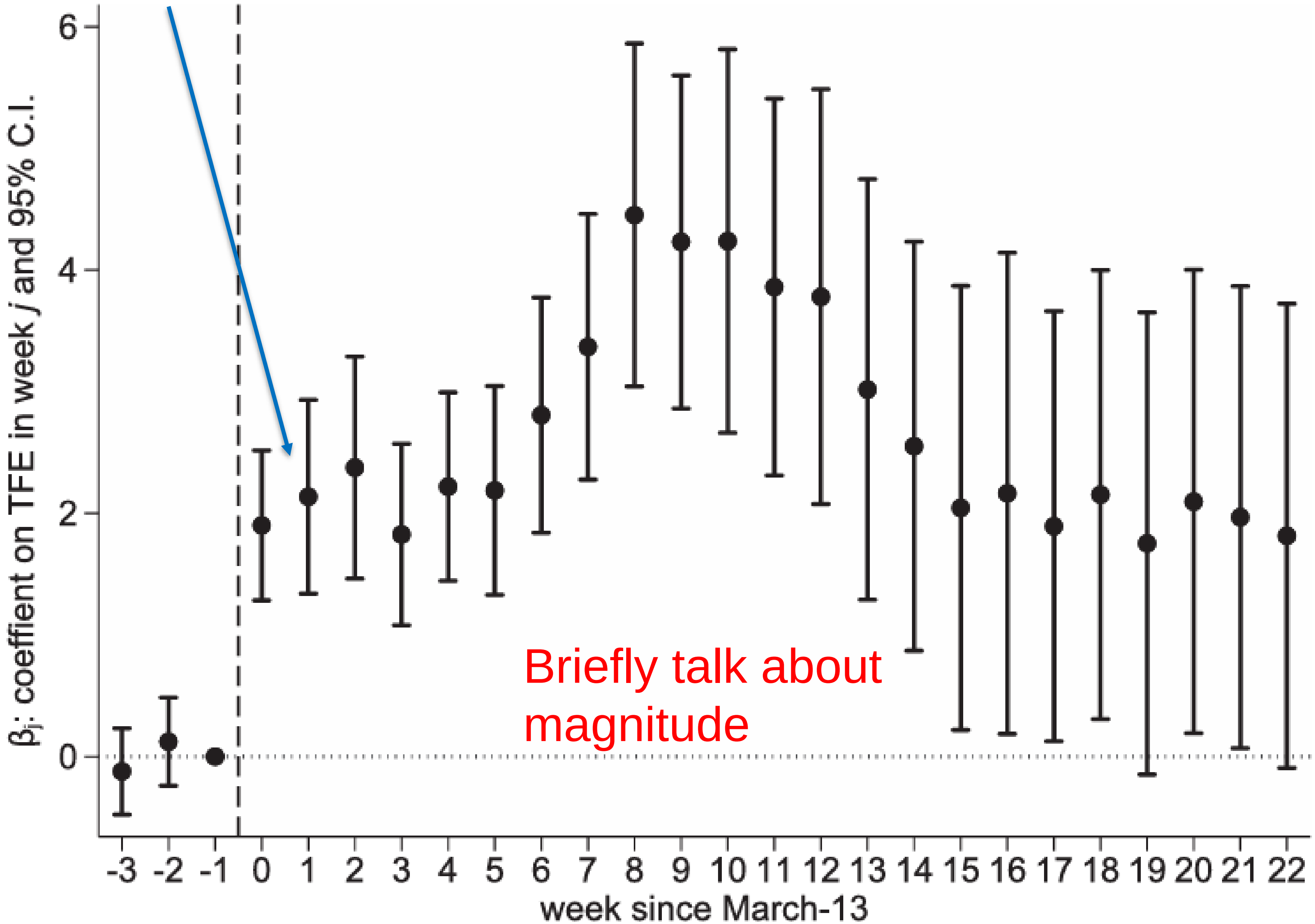


What's the main takeaway?

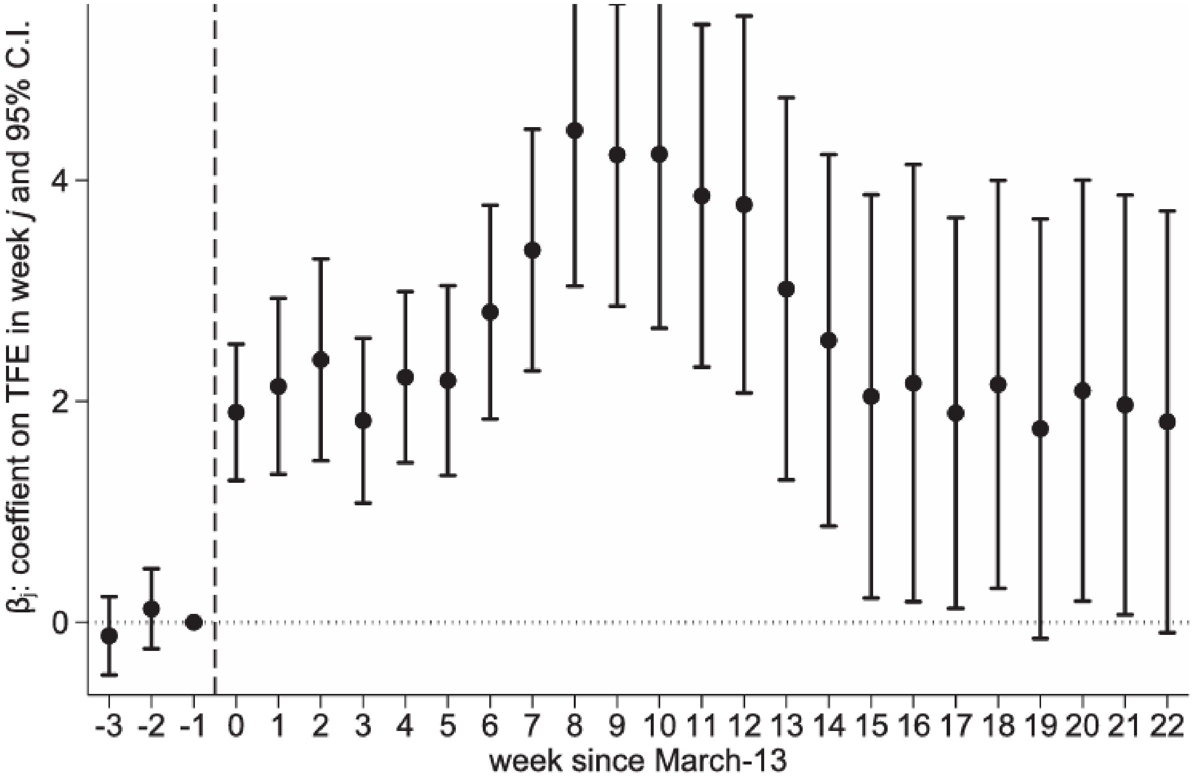



βj: coeffient on TFE in week j and 95% C.I.
6
4
2
0
-3 -2 -1 0 1 2 3 4 5 6 7 8 9 10 11 12 13 14 15 16 17 18 19 20 21 22
week since March-13
Do these estimates “prove” that
the parallel trends assumption holds?

Each additional decade of TFE is associated with a 2 percentage point increase in the likelihood of non-essential visits. This is large relative to…



- Allow time for questions
  - Maybe tell an anecdote?
  - Can you say something here about threats to identification?

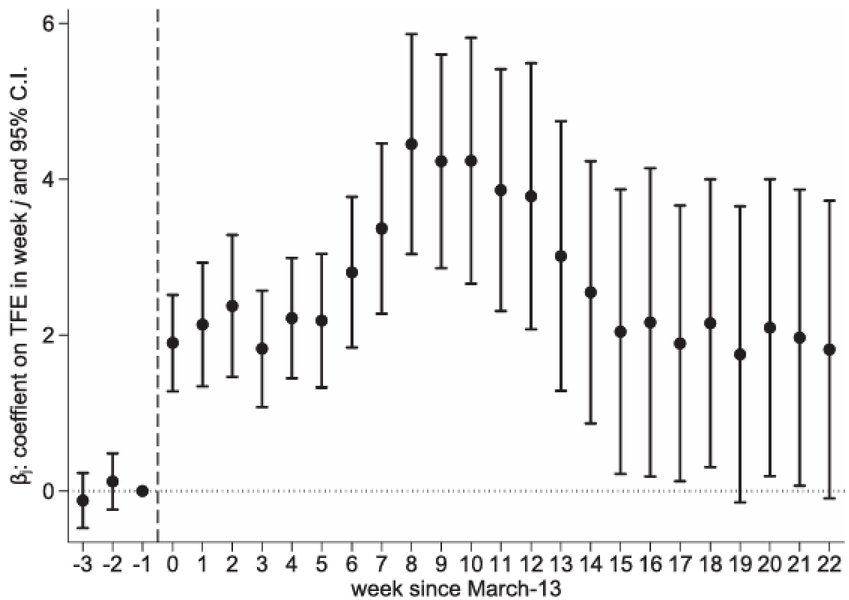


It’s a BIG mistake to squeeze two figures onto one slide…

Can you read the labels on the axes?

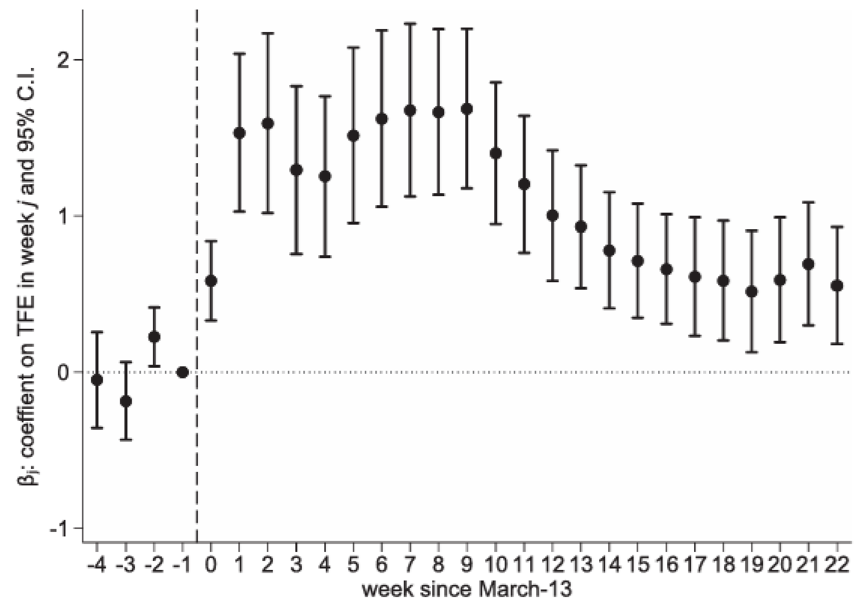
(a) Non-essential Visits

(Unacast)

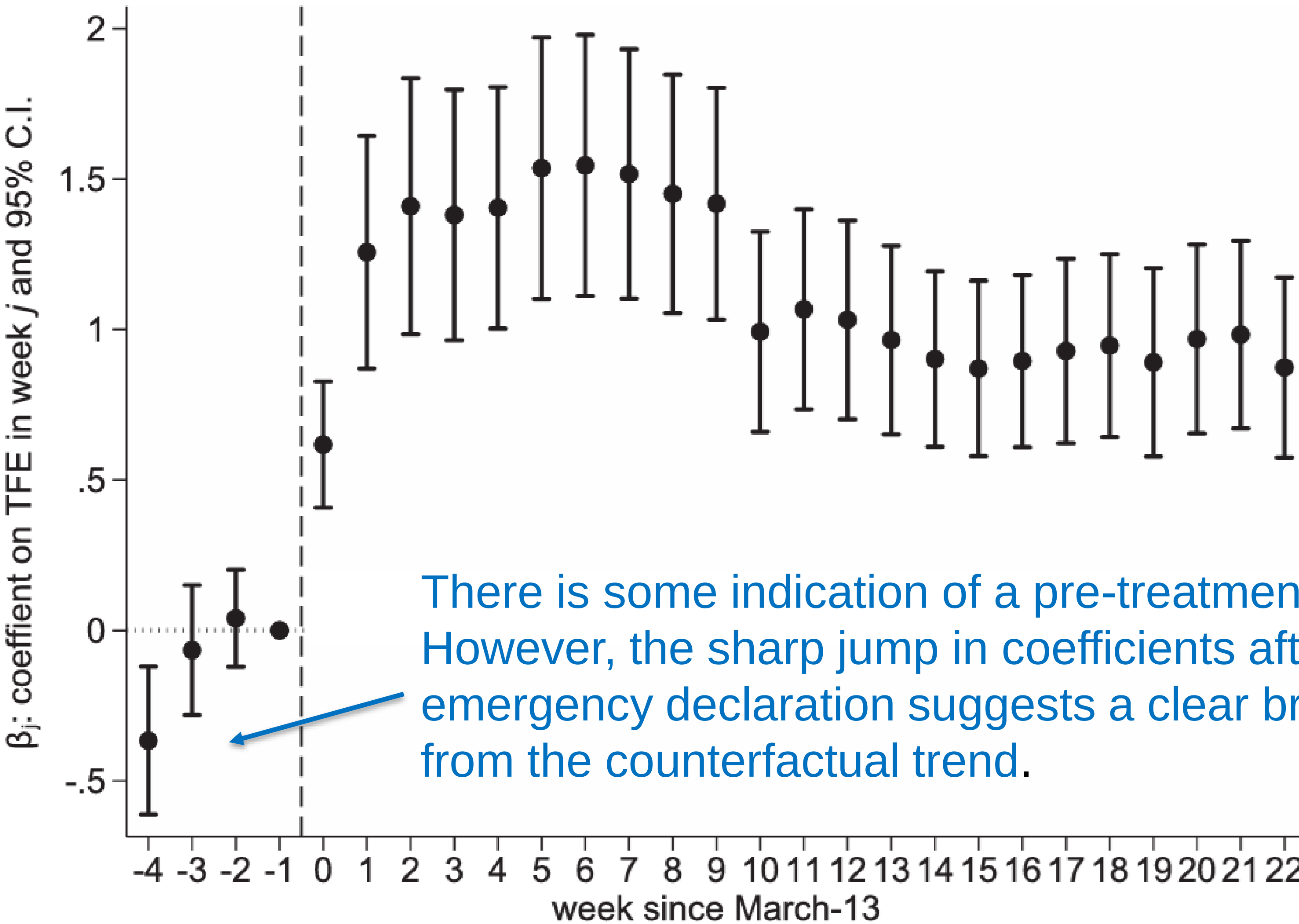


(b) Time in Workplaces

(Google Community Mobility)



This is your chance to explain any pre-treatment trend



There is some indication of a pre-treatment trend. However, the sharp jump in coefficients after the emergency declaration suggests a clear break from the counterfactual trend.

After your main results

- Limit yourself to one or two robustness checks and/or falsification tests
  - Hold the others in reserve

- Job market candidates might want to briefly talk about their research agenda when wrapping up

- Try to spend some time on magnitude
  - Describing magnitude is surprisingly difficult…

Handling questions

- Some audience members **LOVE** your research so much that they take over the seminar
  - “I see where you’re going with that. That’s a really good point. Can we follow up right after the talk? I want to make sure I understand what you’re saying.”
- Some audience members won’t let go of a point
  - “You’re right. If X,Y, and Z are true, then that would bias my results upwards. That’s a good point. I am not sure that the data exist to test that…”

Handling questions

- Don’t be afraid to say “I don’t know”

- Don’t be afraid to ask if you don’t understand a question
  - “I agree that Z is a determinant of Y, but why would it be systematically correlated with treatment in my context?”